ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Stance complement clauses

Choose that-clauses, wh-clauses, to-infinitives and anticipatory patterns to encode evaluation, evidence and responsibility. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use stance complement clauses to make the source and strength of a stance explicit through complementation choice while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Choose that-clauses, wh-clauses, to-infinitives and anticipatory patterns to encode evaluation, evidence and responsibility.

MODEL

The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.

stance noun/adjective/verb + licensed complement clause

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

Outcome 1 Recognise the main stance complement clauses patterns in authentic contexts.	Outcome 2 Choose a form that accurately expresses make the source and strength of a stance explicit through complementation choice.
Outcome 3 Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.	Outcome 4 Use the structure appropriately in advanced academic, institutional and analytical writing.

Build meaning before form

Choose that-clauses, wh-clauses, to-infinitives and anticipatory patterns to encode evaluation, evidence and responsibility.

What stance complement clauses communicates

Choose that-clauses, wh-clauses, to-infinitives and anticipatory patterns to encode evaluation, evidence and responsibility.

The central purpose is to make the source and strength of a stance explicit through complementation choice. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.	a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun
We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.	the writer's disposition toward making a conclusion
The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.	evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: stance noun/adjective/verb + licensed complement clause. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model "The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed." shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Noun complement	stance noun + that-clause	The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.
Adjective complement	adjective + that/to-clause	We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.
Verb complement	stance verb + wh/that-clause	The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun	Noun complement
the writer's disposition toward making a conclusion	Adjective complement
evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation	Verb complement

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in advanced academic, institutional and analytical writing. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02
stance noun/adjective/verb	licensed complement clause

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: make the source and strength of a stance explicit through complementation choice.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits advanced academic, institutional and analytical writing.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Noun complement	stance noun + that-clause	The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.
Adjective complement	adjective + that/to-clause	We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.
Verb complement	stance verb + wh/that-clause	The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.	a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun
We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.	the writer's disposition toward making a conclusion
The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.	evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not confuse a noun complement with a relative clause describing the noun.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not let the complement imply a stronger commitment than the stance adjective.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Choose a reporting verb whose evidential strength the data can support.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun?

OPTIONS The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed. · We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful. · The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the writer's disposition toward making a conclusion?

OPTIONS We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful. · The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed. · The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation?

OPTIONS The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed. · The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed. · We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does "The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed." communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun · the writer's disposition toward making a conclusion · evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does "We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful." communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the writer's disposition toward making a conclusion · evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation · a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does "The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed." communicate in this context?

OPTIONS evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation · a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun · the writer's disposition toward making a conclusion

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Noun complement / Adjective complement / Verb complement · Gap 2: a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun / the writer’s disposition toward making a conclusion / evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Adjective complement / Verb complement / Noun complement · Gap 2: the writer’s disposition toward making a conclusion / evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation / a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Verb complement / Noun complement / Adjective complement · Gap 2: evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation / a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun / the writer’s disposition toward making a conclusion

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

03 · PRACTICE STAGE

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun: _____. Choose the model that expresses the writer's disposition toward making a conclusion: _____. Choose the model that expresses evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation: _____. Choose the model built with stance noun + that-clause: _____. Choose the model built with adjective + that/to-clause: _____. Choose the model built with stance verb + wh/that-clause: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed. · The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed. · We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The _____ the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed. We are _____ that the difference is meaningful. The analysis _____ the earlier model failed. State the full structural pattern for Noun complement: _____. State the full structural pattern for Adjective complement: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “It is possible that the estimate is biased.” using the Noun complement pattern to express a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “We do not readily conclude that the difference matters.” using the Adjective complement pattern to express the writer’s disposition toward making a conclusion.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The analysis explains the failure of the earlier model.” using the Verb complement pattern to express evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “It is possible that the estimate is biased.” using the Noun complement pattern to express a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Noun complement to express a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Adjective complement to express the writer's disposition toward making a conclusion, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Verb complement to express evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

07 · RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____

R5 · REVIEW FOCUS

Apply this decision to a new example, then justify it: Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: make the source and strength of a stance explicit through complementation choice..

_____
_____

R6 · REVIEW FOCUS

Apply this decision to a new example, then justify it: Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns..

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.

Noun complement is the best match because a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun.

A2

We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.

Adjective complement is the best match because the writer’s disposition toward making a conclusion.

A3

The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.

Verb complement is the best match because evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation.

A4

a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun

The Noun complement pattern communicates a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun.

A5

the writer’s disposition toward making a conclusion

The Adjective complement pattern communicates the writer’s disposition toward making a conclusion.

A6

evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation

The Verb complement pattern communicates evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Noun complement / a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun

The structure belongs to the Noun complement pattern. Its communicative purpose is a proposition packaged as the content of an abstract noun.

B2

Adjective complement / the writer’s disposition toward making a conclusion

The structure belongs to the Adjective complement pattern. Its communicative purpose is the writer’s disposition toward making a conclusion.

B3

Verb complement / evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation

The structure belongs to the Verb complement pattern. Its communicative purpose is evidence presented as supporting an embedded explanation.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.

Noun complement: stance noun + that-clause.

C2

We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.

Adjective complement: adjective + that/to-clause.

C3

The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.

Verb complement: stance verb + wh/that-clause.

C4

The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.

Noun complement: stance noun + that-clause.

C5

We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.

Adjective complement: adjective + that/to-clause.

C6

The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.

Verb complement: stance verb + wh/that-clause.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

possibility that

Noun complement requires “possibility that” in this model. stance noun + that-clause.

D2

reluctant to conclude

Adjective complement requires “reluctant to conclude” in this model. adjective + that/to-clause.

D3

demonstrates why

Verb complement requires “demonstrates why” in this model. stance verb + wh/that-clause.

D4

stance noun + that-clause

Noun complement is built as stance noun + that-clause.

D5

adjective + that/to-clause

Adjective complement is built as adjective + that/to-clause.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.

stance noun + that-clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended noun complement effect.

E2

We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful.

adjective + that/to-clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended adjective complement effect.

E3

The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed.

stance verb + wh/that-clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended verb complement effect.

E4

The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed.

stance noun + that-clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended noun complement effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The possibility that the estimate is biased cannot be dismissed. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses stance noun + that-clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

We are reluctant to conclude that the difference is meaningful. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses adjective + that/to-clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The analysis demonstrates why the earlier model failed. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses stance verb + wh/that-clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

07 · FEEDBACK

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

WELEARN STUDY SEQUENCE

01	02	03	04
complete guide	exercise workbook	answer key	retrieval review

RETRIEVAL

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.